



theWindow

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In a Missional God's Image

Preston Graham



from the Pastor

One of our five core commitments at CPC is printed on the back cover of our bulletin:

We are committed to being a multi-cultural church and church planting movement. We believe that the church, the household of God, is an essential element of the gospel into which people of every culture and nation are welcomed. While

affirming that every follower of Christ is called to be a witness to the truth and grace of God revealed in Jesus Christ in both word and deed, we also believe that true evangelism is best accomplished through church planting. It is therefore our ambition to be not only a growing church, but also a growing church planting movement. While holding to a time-honored understanding of faith, we are strategically progressive. Our aim is to plant churches that reach the different cultures in our city, Southern New England, and the world.

This statement means that in the image of God we desire to be missional. This year, we will be initiating two important projects aimed at fulfilling this theologically informed commitment.

First, we should never forget that we must always be a church planting movement within our own city of greater New Haven. Especially given our post-Christian context, we cannot cease to think of ourselves as always participating in church planting *here* in New Haven, however organized we might appear. Toward this end, we are initiating the "Christianity Explored" curriculum. "Christianity Explored" is a small-group focused ministry of hospitality and investigation using selected passages from the gospel of Mark in order to introduce our neighbors, both in word and in deed, to the love and truth of Christ. Through fellowship meals and conversation in the various neighborhoods of greater New Haven, we hope to make the gospel presence of Christ more and more accessible to our neighbors. Pray for the power of the gospel to be manifest in and through our church, and especially our small groups, as we continue the church planting vision in greater New Haven. Dare to believe in the power of God to save even your own neighbor!

Second, we should never cease in a vision not only to experience church planting ourselves in and around greater New Haven, but also to *extend* the power of God's truth and grace into Southern New England and throughout the world. Toward this end, we will initiate our second church plant in ten years, this time focusing on the Southern New England city of Danbury. In

God's perfect providence, he has gathered to our church an exhilarating vision and passion for the gospel together with a significant number of human and fiscal resources that are specifically focused on Danbury. Together with many others who we have been in contact with us and who live in the greater Danbury region, we are excited to initiate the first phase of church planting, which consists of launch team development (the new catch word for "core group") and the search for a church planter. Our hope is that over the next several months, God will bring together a growing number of people in greater Danbury whose identity is being forged around three core values that point to a specific kind of church. These three core values are a *gospel* focus, a *sacramental* focus, and a *missional* focus, so the Danbury church will express the same theological commitments that are listed in our bulletin. Please join together with those living in greater Danbury in praying for the formation of a kind of community where it is safe to be deeply flawed and broken. In such a context we hope that many will discover the life-transforming love of God as revealed in Jesus Christ and mediated through the church in both word and deed. In closing, we should never forget that no project can possibly plant the presence of Christ in itself! Only the transforming power of a missional God in our midst through the Holy Spirit makes us missional in His image and accomplishes true missions! A missional identity means that we aim to be in the world (if not of the world), but always for the world! It means participating with God in being otherworldly without being anti-world. It means remembering the first part of the familiar affirmation, "*God so loved the world*, that he gave his only begotten Son" (John 3:16). Because of God's love for the world, we can love New Haven and Danbury rather than fear them.

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Serving with Joy

Joe Shields



Briefings

Serving the church—sure, OK—but with joy? It's no easy task for sure, and yet we all know someone who seems to serve with what appears to be great pleasure. (I confess that I have had less than edifying thoughts about such people at times.) Others seem to have a hard time finding a place to serve and appear to do very little if anything to contribute to the church. (I confess similar thoughts about these people, but in this case I do it while pretending not to be one of them.) Few would question that as Christians we are called to serve, and scripture makes it clear that we are called to do so cheerfully, but how? I do not intend to write a theological or apologetic article about Christian service, nor am I qualified to do so. Beginning with the premise that we are all called to serve, I will just provide my thoughts on the topic as a servant leader, thoughts that I hope will help us all maintain the proper perspective on our own service in the church. The considerations that I find most helpful can be addressed with three questions: (1) Why should we serve? (2) What kind of work are we doing? (3) How can we do that work cheerfully?

So why should we serve the church? Put simply, God has called us to serve (Romans 12, Ephesians 4). Most of us are familiar with Christ's response to the question about the greatest commandment: "Love the Lord your God . . . and love your neighbor." Who should serve? All believers. Paul "urges" the church in Rome, "offer your bodies as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God." The Holy Spirit has gifted all believers to do some kind of work. Paul also reminds the church at Ephesus "to each one of us grace has been given as Christ apportioned it." We are all called to serve and equipped to serve Christ's church.



The Guatemalan mountains show the glory of God's world.

So what kind of work are we called and equipped to do specifically? Specifically, I don't know. But generally speaking I do know that, as believers, we are all doing kingdom work whatever our area of service might be (Ephesians 4:12, 13, 16). This thought excites me. We would probably all agree that preaching and teaching build God's kingdom, but we're not all preachers and teachers. As lay people we would probably agree that evangelism builds God's kingdom, but I am afraid this is

where many of us stop seeing service as kingdom work. Look how Paul describes kingdom work in Ephesians 4:16: "From [Christ] the whole body, joined and held together *by every supporting ligament*, grows and builds itself up in love, *as each part does its work*." So playing guitar builds God's kingdom? Apparently so. Choosing blinds for the sanctuary builds God's kingdom? Apparently so. Mowing the church lawn builds God's kingdom? We are assured from scripture that it does. When believers serve the church, they are doing kingdom work. There is no second-class service in God's economy.



Dr. Lei examines a young Guatemalan patient.

OK, so we are called to serve, and all service is kingdom work. Great! How on earth do we serve cheerfully as scripture tells us to? Certainly remembering that we are in fact serving God's kingdom helps. Also, when Paul tells the church in Rome to offer their bodies as living sacrifices, he begins the statement with "in view of God's mercy" (12:1). Ouch! That just knocks the wind out of me. When I feel that my brothers and sisters in Christ are imposing upon me by asking me to serve, this statement is a quick and sobering reality check. What God has done for us in Christ is unapproachable in comparison to what we can offer in the way of service. I encourage you to keep this phrase in the forefront of your mind. I ask this not to bind your conscience with guilt so that you serve with obligatory contempt. Rather, remembering God's mercy should allow us to serve with humility and gratitude for what Christ has done for us. With this in mind, service takes on a new perspective. In view of God's mercy, service is not a burden, but a privilege. It is not half-hearted, but diligent. We no longer do the bare minimum of service but instead become generous servants one to another. If we keep God's mercy in view, we are no longer apathetic about his kingdom work, but cheerful. Ah! Finally, we have arrived. Cheerful service flows from God's mercy, not from our desperate attempts to hide a begrudging heart with a phony smile and false humility. It is a struggle to be sure, but we are not left without hope. If we don't put confidence in our own flesh for salvation, why then should we put confidence in our own ability to serve cheerfully? Hmm . . . once again, we find ourselves at the gospel.

To review: we are all called to serve, all our service is kingdom work, and we can serve cheerfully if we keep in mind what God has done for us in Christ. CPC is full of opportunities to serve. If you don't know where to serve, please speak with a servant leader for suggestions about where help is needed. ❖

Memories of Guatemala

An Interview with the Guatemala Team



What was most surprising to you about your time in Guatemala?

Clay Daniel: The friendliness of the people in general, but also the shyness of the Chorti people in particular. The hearty welcome we got shows that these people have real joy, but the more withdrawn posture of the Chorti was a reminder of how different—and difficult—their lives are.

Diane Miller: Most surprising was that I was not, in fact, in Guatemala! (For those not here at the time, my passport apparently fell out of my "organizational folder." The passport spent the week hidden in the study center's parlor sofa, meaning I spent the week in New Haven.)

Jason Klostreich: Most surprising to me was the joy that the people of Guatemala had. They seemed to be very content and happy despite low income and poor living conditions. They seemed far happier and more at peace than many of my fellow American suburbanites. It was also amazing to see how expressive the people were about their faith. Religion was definitely not a private affair.

Barbara Battista: I was surprised at how fast the time passed. I felt I had just started adjusting to my surroundings and then we were on our way home. I would have liked to spend more time with the Chorti people.

My kids were surprised at how small the Chorti children were compared to them. We gave a 13-year-old boy a ride down the mountain, and Kevin towered over him. Some things were the same, though: they giggled at Jeff's jokes and loved the gifts of candy.



The Guatemala team pauses for a photo.

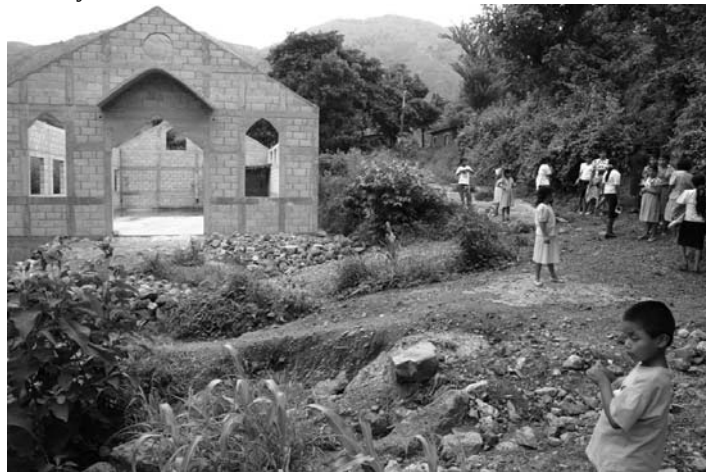
What did you learn from the experience of preparing for and going on the Guatemala trip?

Clay: I learned how much I value and idolize the comfort and familiarity of my own culture. Being in a radically different place was exciting at first, but later on it began to remind me of

the things I was missing back home. I saw that I love the idea of "home"—on this earth, at least—probably too much.

Diane: I was most grateful for the opportunity to see CPC as a whole participate in the preparation for the trip through giving, prayer, encouragement, preparation and donation of materials, and more. It is a joy and delight to see the members of the body working together to bring glory to our God through service. I had the opportunity to learn through the struggle of not going, finally finding rest in the assurance that God's plans are perfect.

Jason: I learned that Jesus is everywhere, even where we'd least expect him. I now have a profound respect for the people of developing countries. Even though sin is everywhere, I now see other cultures as more rich than our own in respect to family and identity.



The church building comes together in the Chorti village.

Barbara: As Diane mentioned in the last newsletter, I learned about "going but not knowing." We learned some about the country and culture before we went but didn't really know what it would be like for us, and that anxiety overtook me and my family. The kids had never flown before, we didn't know much Spanish, and we were concerned about communicating at all, not to mention sharing the gospel. Were we truly ready? The trip was indeed a walk of faith. We convinced ourselves it would be an adventure we didn't want to miss and that it would change not only our own lives but others' lives, too. This trip had a purpose, not like our own selfish vacations. We were going to help build a church so that God's message could be spread to more Chorti people. And it was well worth it.

God worked trust in our hearts and taught us that He was in control no matter what we experienced. I think we all learned that God does have our best interest at heart even when we do not know where his plans will lead us.

Through the unexpected events—Diane's lost passport, missing luggage and Sunday School materials, etc.—God was in control. He pulled the team together as he showed us his solutions. We all grew from having to stretch past our comfort zone to serve His goal. Every one served in areas that God had prepared for us. It was a great and terrifying experience, well worth doing again.

("Memories of Guatemala" continued on page 4)

All photographs courtesy of Lei Chen.

("Memories of Guatemala" continued from page 3)

What was most memorable about the trip?

Clay: I would say the breathtaking scenery, combined with varying scenes of people, animals, etc. that brought home the material poverty of the Guatemalan people.

Diane: In pre-trip meetings, the youngest three team members were somewhat reserved. After the trip, however, Chris, Laura, and Kevin didn't need any encouragement to share their experiences. The excitement in their voices was a blessing.

Jason: The beautiful scenery, the beautiful people, the mountain church, the Chorti people, doing manual labor with the group, but most of all beating Clay and Jeff in water volleyball!

Barbara: Kevin's moment was the ride in the back of the truck, standing up as it climbed 4,000 feet to the church. We were truly on an adventure into the high mountains on just a winding dirt road barely wide enough for the truck.

Laura loved the ride into our village. Everything was new and exciting. The sights reminded her that she was not in the United States. We saw smoking volcanoes, people begging in the streets for food and money, and pineapples growing in orchards behind handmade stick fences. As we got farther from Guatemala City, the buildings and homes showed the economic differences very clearly. The people along the way lived in houses barely livable to our standards. We were amazed at the how they used every space to grow corn and coffee. They utilized every inch to survive and we waste our surplus. Life has a different beat.

During the church service I looked out over the valley and realized that I was sitting in a Chorti village church in Guatemala

worshipping with other Christians I had just met, and I realized how much God Loved all his people. It didn't matter that we could barely understand each other and lived completely different lives. We shared one belief, one God. Jesus binds us together by His love and gives us an overwhelming peace in his presence. ❖

("In a Missional God's Image" continued from page 1)

Because of God's mission to the world, we can have great hope for New Haven and Danbury rather than despair. Because of our doctrine of original sin, we don't think we are less sinful than any other people in New Haven and Danbury, though we may very well be more sinful. Because of our doctrine of common grace, we believe that we can learn from the people of New Haven and Danbury because God is at work in people of all faiths and none, though not unto salvation apart from Christ. And because God's special grace is no respecter of persons, we believe that all people in our cities are potentially the children of God! Believing these things, we will be even more bold and more hospitable without compromising the gospel. We will welcome people who, like us, do not have it all together. We will joyfully bear the burdens of the world as our burdens in Christ. We will seek to avoid isolating clichés that are unique to any one Christian subculture and carefully explain Christian concepts and classical terminology. In sum, we will talk and act as if our New Haven and Danbury neighbors are always present and welcomed! Please join me in praying for the transforming power of a *missional* God in our midst! ❖



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